Seven Days, Twenty-Eight Days, and the Number 61: The Road from the Ballot to a Government

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The ballots have been counted. The next part of Israeli democracy happens in quiet rooms rather than at voting stations. The lists that passed the threshold for the 26th Knesset sat with President Isaac Herzog and told him whom they recommend to form the next government.

It is worth slowing down to understand what that means, because these weeks are full of noise. Knowing the rules helps us hear the noise for what it is.

What the official results say

The Central Elections Committee presented the final seat totals to the President on Wednesday, 4 November 2026. Those are the results he works from. The eleven lists above the threshold, and their official seats, are:

Likud: 27
Yashar!: 21
Together (B'Yachad): 12
Joint List: 11
The Democrats: 8
Ra'am: 8
Yisrael Beytenu: 7
Otzma Yehudit: 7
United Torah Judaism: 7
Shas: 6
Religious Zionism–Zehut: 6

That is 120 seats. The lists that campaigned as a change bloc hold 48 (Yashar 21, B'Yachad 12, the Democrats 8, Yisrael Beytenu 7). The two Arab-led lists hold 19 (Joint List 11, Ra'am 8). The outgoing-allies bloc holds 53 (Likud 27, Otzma Yehudit 7, United Torah Judaism 7, Shas 6, Religious Zionism–Zehut 6). Neither large camp has 61 on its own.

The new Knesset was sworn in today, Tuesday 10 November 2026.

What the consultations are

Israelis do not vote for a prime minister. We vote for lists, and the lists become Knesset factions. The President's job is to find the member of Knesset with the best chance of building a government that the Knesset will approve.

The rules come from Basic Law: The Government. Section 7 says that once a new government must be formed, the President, "after consulting the representatives of the Parliamentary Groups," assigns the task to a member of Knesset who has agreed to take it on. When the consultations happen before the new Knesset has convened, as they did this time, the President consults the representatives of the lists that will sit in it.

In practice, each faction sends a delegation to the President's Residence. Each one says whom it recommends, or that it recommends no one. The meetings are usually broadcast, and they are the first time we hear, on the record, where every party stands after the vote.

The clock

The Basic Law sets the clock, and the clock matters.

First, seven days. The President must assign the task "within seven days from the publication of the election results." The results went to the President on 4 November 2026. On Sunday 8 November, inside that window, he assigned the task to Yashar chairman Gadi Eisenkot.

Second, twenty-eight days. Under Section 8, the member of Knesset who gets the task has 28 days to form a government. The President may extend this "by additional periods, as long as all together they shall not exceed 14 days." So Eisenkot has up to 42 days in all.

Third, if that fails. Under Section 9, if the candidate cannot form a government in time, the President has three days either to give the task to another member of Knesset or to tell the Speaker that he sees no way to form a government. A second candidate gets 28 days, and the law gives no extension for that round.

Fourth, the Knesset itself. Under Section 10, if that round also fails, a majority of members of Knesset may ask the President in writing, within 21 days, to give the task to a specific member who has agreed in writing. If that does not produce a government either, the Basic Law treats the Knesset as dispersed, and Israel goes back to elections.

That is a long road. It is also a road with exits, and every party knows exactly where they are.

Why 61 matters

A government needs the confidence of the Knesset, and a stable one needs 61 of the 120 seats.

The final seat count is in. Neither large camp reached 61 on its own.

The arithmetic has to run through one of three doors: a party crossing from one camp to the other, a government that depends in some way on one or both Arab-led lists, or some form of broad or unity arrangement between large parties that spent the campaign running against each other.

Each door would have a lock. Several party leaders said during the campaign and since, on the record, whom they will not sit with. Those statements were part of what the President weighed when he asked the simple question that the consultations come down to: who can actually get to 61?

Two further points are worth holding onto. First, the President is not bound to choose the leader of the largest party, though the person with the most recommendations usually gets the first chance. Representatives of 67 incoming members recommended Eisenkot, and 46 recommended Benjamin Netanyahu. United Torah Judaism, with seven seats, recommended no one. Those 67 recommendations are not the same thing as 61 coalition votes. Second, a recommendation is not a coalition. A faction can recommend a candidate and still drive a very hard bargain afterwards.

An open question, handled with care

Hanging over all of this is the investigation the Central Elections Committee chairman asked the Shin Bet to open into suspected foreign interference. According to reports, the suspicions concern money from Qatar, which Doha has categorically denied. The committee has said, with the approval of its chairman, Justice Noam Sohlberg, that the investigation will not affect the final results submitted to the President and does not concern any particular community. The Shin Bet said the inquiry is "focused and limited" and asked the public to avoid speculation about its substance.

So the honest position for now is a question, not a conclusion. What will the investigation find, and will its findings matter to anyone's choices as a government is formed? We do not know yet. Until we do, the Torah's standard of guarding our speech applies to all of us, and especially to those of us who write. No community and no person should be treated as guilty because of a report about an inquiry that has not finished.

Why it matters

There is something steadying in a process with clear rules. Elections can feel like a storm. The Basic Law turns the storm into a calendar: seven days, twenty-eight days, fourteen more, three days, another twenty-eight, twenty-one.

Our tradition knows that a people needs structure to hold its arguments. The consultations are a small piece of that structure. They made every party say out

loud, in front of the whole country, what it really wants. Whatever we each hope the outcome will be, that is worth watching closely, and worth explaining to one another with patience and respect.

Official results: Central Elections Committee, final seat allocation presented to the President on 4 November 2026. Legal text: Basic Law: The Government (Knesset English translation). The assignment of the task: President Isaac Herzog, Sunday 8 November 2026; representatives of 67 incoming members recommended Gadi Eisenkot, 46 recommended Benjamin Netanyahu, and United Torah Judaism recommended no one.

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